

10 General Recommendations Across Projects

Extracted from the recommendation sections of written evaluations (521 individual recommendations from 117 reviews covering 36 projects). Recommendations were selected either based on how frequently they appeared across different projects or because the advice is broadly applicable to any project team.

Approximate share of projects in which the topic appeared in the recommendation section of at least one review. Calculated using a combination of automated extraction and keywords, so this is an approximate indicator of frequency, not an exact measurement. Ranked by prevalence.

#	Recommendation	Why Evaluators Care	Approx. Prevalence
1	Test the solution with real users outside your own team, not just internally.	The most frequent and consistent recommendation across the entire competition. Without feedback from independent people, it is impossible to verify that the product solves a real problem and is usable.	~100% of projects (36/36)
2	First complete and strengthen the core/MVP, then add additional features.	For many projects, evaluators warned against scope creep at the expense of completing and polishing the core functionality, which is more important for the defense.	~75% of projects (27/36)
3	Replace general claims with measurable numbers and define and track specific success metrics.	Evaluators repeatedly called for claims to be supported by measurement. Claims about speed, reliability, or benefits without numbers were not considered evidence.	~69% of projects (25/36)
4	Verify customers' willingness to pay and the business model before further technical expansion.	For product-oriented projects, evaluators consistently requested evidence of commercial viability, such as a paying customer or pilot deployment, before further feature development.	~42% of projects (15/36)
5	Introduce security and load testing, ideally including an independent audit, before production deployment.	For projects involving data, payments, or critical infrastructure, evaluators repeatedly requested penetration testing, security audits, or load testing.	~44% of projects (16/36)
6	Document the development process and key decisions.	Reports that only describe the result without explaining how it was achieved make it difficult to evaluate the process and continue the work in the future. Evaluators want to see <i>why</i> , not just <i>what</i> .	~42% of projects (15/36)

#	Recommendation	Why Evaluators Care	Approx. Prevalence
7	Clearly formulate and defend the competitive advantage (USP) by comparing the solution with existing alternatives.	For many projects, it remained unclear what made the solution better than available alternatives. Evaluators considered this a significant gap in demonstrating viability.	~33% of projects (12/36)
8	Address legal, regulatory, and certification requirements early.	Hardware, healthcare, and security projects sometimes overlooked certifications, standards, or legal requirements that could prevent real-world deployment.	~31% of projects (11/36)
9	Set specific milestones and a timeline for further development.	Without a clear plan with deadlines, it is difficult to assess the pace of progress and the feasibility of the next steps. Evaluators consider this a standard part of a report.	~25% of projects (9/36)
10	Clearly separate what is completed, what is planned, and what is merely an intention or claim in the report.	Mixing the actual current state with plans or business promises reduces the credibility of the report. Evaluators value transparently acknowledging unfinished work.	~22% of projects (8/36, but strongly expressed)